Preliminary Target Market & Personas

POOLD - Milestone 2

Prepared for SENG 455 / BCOM 450 - Milestone 2 Proof of Concept

1. Preliminary Target Market

Primary initial segment

University students in the UVic / Victoria area who purchase groceries and household essentials, value cost and convenience, and participate in a student community through roommates, friends, residences, clubs, or other campus groups.

The segment is intentionally narrower than "all students." POOLD is initially aimed at students living independently or with roommates who can benefit from larger package sizes but face barriers such as limited storage, spoilage, upfront cost, transportation, or not having someone to split with.

Target-market profile

Geographic	UVic / Greater Victoria for the initial proof of concept and early validation.
Demographic	University students; interview participants were primarily in their early 20s, with one participant age 27.
Behavioural	Regular grocery/household shoppers; many shop weekly or every two weeks, often at Walmart or Costco; shared shopping and e-transfer already occur informally.
Need-based	Wants lower cost and convenience without excessive quantity, waste, storage burden, or repeated coordination.
Community context	Roommates, friends, residences, clubs, and other university groups provide natural trust and pickup networks.

Why this segment first

- Interviewees already purchase common grocery and household items repeatedly.
- Bulk purchasing is already familiar, especially for meat/chicken, rice, eggs, toiletries, and other non-perishables.
- Roommate-based sharing and manual cost splitting already exist, giving POOLD an existing workflow to improve.
- Students identified barriers that POOLD is designed to address: package size, storage, spoilage, upfront cost, transportation, and finding someone to split with.
- Campus provides recognizable public meeting locations and a verifiable university identity that may improve trust.

1.1 How the Target User Evolved from Milestone 1

Milestone 1 initially described buyers broadly as students and close-knit communities, and hypothesized organizers such as Costco regulars, PAC leaders, and volunteers who were already making the trip and could be compensated for gas/time. The first interview round supports keeping university students as the initial buyer segment, but it weakens the assumption that there will naturally be a reliable organizer pool.

Milestone 1 hypothesis	What discovery suggests now	Persona implication
Buyers: students / close-knit communities	Still reasonable as an initial segment. Interviewees were students, many had roommates, and shared purchasing already occurs informally.	Keep a UVic/Victoria student member persona, with trust and convenience constraints grounded in interviews.
Organizers: Costco regulars, PAC leaders, volunteers	Not yet validated. Most interviewees preferred being members rather than organizers, and several would only organize for friends/roommates.	Treat the organizer as an emerging persona and business-model risk, not a proven segment.
Organizer motivation: compensation, connection, reputation	Not established by the current interviews. Some casual roommate trips required no compensation, while organizer willingness remained low.	Test compensation and non-monetary incentives directly before building the model around them.

2. Persona A - Member / Buyer

Maya - The Cost-Conscious Student

Profile & behaviour

- University student in the UVic / Victoria area
- Likely lives independently or with roommates
- Shops for groceries/essentials regularly, often weekly
- Uses stores such as Walmart or Costco depending on access and needs
- Comfortable with group chats and e-transfer for informal splitting

Goals

- Spend less on everyday necessities
- Access bulk pricing without taking the full quantity
- Avoid waste and excessive storage
- Reduce unnecessary shopping trips
- Use a convenient, predictable pickup location

Pain points

- Bulk package is too large for one person
- Limited fridge/freezer/storage space
- Perishables may spoil before use
- Higher upfront cost of large packages
- May lack a car or Costco membership
- Manual coordination and receipt splitting are inconvenient
- May hesitate to trust unfamiliar participants

Needs from POOLD

- Clear share quantity and price
- Transparent estimated savings
- Verified student/community context
- Safe public pickup
- Simple join-and-commit flow
- Clear updates when price, item, or pickup changes

Core job-to-be-done

"Help me access the savings of buying in bulk without making me buy, store, or pay for more than I need."

Evidence behind this persona

- Most interviewees shop on a recurring weekly or biweekly pattern, with Walmart and Costco frequently mentioned.
- Bulk buying is already common for some staples, while storage, spoilage, and upfront cost limit larger purchases.
- Shared purchases are often managed informally through roommates, group chats, e-transfer, and receipt splitting.

3. Persona B - Occasional Organizer

Jordan - The Occasional Organizer

Secondary / emerging composite persona. Evidence is weaker than for the member persona because organizer willingness was limited in the first interview round.

Profile & behaviour

- University student with transportation access and/or bulk-store access
- Already making a Walmart/Costco trip for personal shopping
- More comfortable organizing for roommates or friends than strangers
- Likely prefers a small group rather than a large public order
- May organize occasionally rather than every week

Goals

- Complete personal shopping efficiently
- Help roommates/friends access lower prices
- Avoid fronting money for other people
- Keep coordination and pickup simple
- Potentially recover travel/gas cost or receive another benefit

Pain points

- Collecting everyone's requests
- Deciding whose card/car to use
- Tracking who owes money
- Last-minute product or price changes
- Coordinating a pickup time
- Sorting purchases after shopping
- Workload becomes less attractive as group size grows

Needs from POOLD

- Fast group setup
- Automatic quantities and totals
- Clear deadlines and commitments
- Payment-status tracking
- Small/manageable group size
- Shopping and packing lists
- Pickup management
- Optional transparent organizer compensation

Core job-to-be-done

"Let me organize a group purchase without turning a normal shopping trip into a second job."

Evidence behind this persona

- No interviewee reported organizing group purchases beyond informal roommate trips.
- Most interviewees preferred being members rather than organizers; only limited occasional organizer interest appeared.
    - This directly challenges the Milestone 1 assumption that people would readily take initiative in creating groups.
- Potential organizers described small manageable groups and cited time, transportation, and coordination as constraints.

4. Relationship Between the Two Personas

POOLD is a two-sided experience: members create demand, while organizers make fulfillment possible. The first interview round suggests stronger willingness to join than to organize. For this reason, the organizer persona is not simply a secondary UX case - it is a business-model constraint that must be validated.

Question	Member / Buyer	Organizer
Primary value sought	Lower cost + smaller usable share + convenience	Low-effort coordination + reduced financial/logistics risk
Main barrier	Storage, spoilage, upfront cost, trust, transportation	Time, travel, upfront payment, sorting, coordinating people

5. Key Persona Assumptions Still to Validate

- How often members would actually use recurring group orders rather than one-off purchases.
- How much savings is required before scheduled pickup feels worthwhile.
- Whether verified university identity is enough to overcome concerns about unfamiliar participants.
- What incentive, if any, is sufficient to produce a reliable pool of organizers.
- Whether organizer group sizes larger than the current small-group comfort range can be supported by the app.
- Which product categories provide the best balance of savings, low spoilage risk, and easy splitting.
- Whether users will accept alternatives when an item is out of stock.
- Whether structured notifications are sufficient or participants still need direct messaging.
- Whether product overlap is high enough within the same ordering window to consistently fill bulk packs.

Critical risk to persona-market fit

The member persona is more strongly supported than the organizer persona. If organizer supply remains weak, the marketplace will not function even if member demand is high. Milestone 2 testing should therefore recruit and observe both roles.